ERA 2

Contact & Colonization

1491 – 1607

Exploration · the Columbian Exchange · the Spanish Empire

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did contact among Europe, the Americas, and Africa reshape all three — biologically, economically, and culturally?

KEY TERMS

Caravel · Columbian Exchange · encomienda · casta system · Middle Passage · Bartolomé de las Casas

ALIGNED TO

CED Topics 1.3–1.7 · AMSCO Ch. 1.3–1.7

MOTIVES & MEANS

Why Europe Sailed

God, Gold & Glory

I

Gold

Mercantilism drove nations to seek wealth—gold, silver, and raw materials.

II

God

Catholic and Protestant powers competed to convert souls in the New World.

III

Glory

Land and empire meant power and prestige in a rivalry among European states.

New Tools for a New Age

- Advances in navigation made long ocean voyages possible.
- The **caravel** was faster and more maneuverable; the **astrolabe** and **sextant** measured latitude.
- The magnetic compass let sailors hold a course far from land.



The Age of Contact

1492

Columbus

Reaches the Caribbean, opening the Americas to Europe.

1494

Tordesillas

Spain & Portugal divide the New World between them.

1519

Cortés

Begins the conquest of the Aztec Empire.

1533

Pizarro

Conquers the Inca Empire in Peru.

Columbus, 1492



- Sailing for Spain, Columbus sought a western route to Asia.
- He landed in the Caribbean—believing he had reached the Indies.
- His voyages sparked the **Columbian Exchange** and centuries of conquest.

SECTION

Conquest of the Americas

Cortés & the Aztecs



- In 1519 **Hernán Cortés** led a small force into central Mexico.
- Native allies and steel weapons aided the **conquistadores**.
- But **smallpox** devastated the **Aztecs**—collapsing their defense.

Pizarro & the Inca

- In 1533 **Francisco Pizarro** conquered the **Inca** Empire in Peru.
- He captured and executed the **Inca** ruler, Atahualpa.
- Disease and civil war had already weakened the empire before he arrived.



Why So Few Conquered So Many

WEAPONS

Guns, Steel & Horses

Europeans held a decisive military-technology edge.

→

ALLIANCES

Native Rivalries

Conquistadors recruited peoples resentful of Aztec/Inca rule.

→

DISEASE

Smallpox

Old World disease killed most of the population before battle.

→

RESULT

Collapse

Vast empires fell to only a few hundred Spaniards.

SECTION

The Columbian Exchange

A Two-Way Transfer

The Columbian Exchange

A biological exchange that remade both hemispheres

	OLD WORLD → NEW WORLD	NEW WORLD → OLD WORLD
Crops	Wheat, rice, sugar, bananas	Maize, potatoes, tomatoes, cacao
Animals	Horses, cattle, pigs, sheep	Turkeys
Disease	**Smallpox**, measles, malaria	(few in return)
Impact	Reshaped Native life & the Plains	Fueled Europe's population boom

A World Transformed

I

New Foods

Potatoes and maize fueled a **population boom** across Europe, Africa, and Asia.

II

New Animals

Horses transformed the cultures of the Great Plains; cattle and pigs reshaped the land.

III

A Linked World

Goods, people, and ideas now flowed permanently between the hemispheres.

ERA 2 · CONTACT & COLONIZATION

Demographic Catastrophe

~90%

of Native peoples died

In the century after contact, Old World diseases wiped out as much as **90%** of the Indigenous population of the Americas.

From Disease to the Slave Trade

CAUSE

Population Collapse

Native deaths create a massive labor shortage.

→

RESPONSE

Turn to Africa

The Spanish and Portuguese seek enslaved African labor.

→

SYSTEM

Atlantic Slave Trade

Millions are forced across the Atlantic.

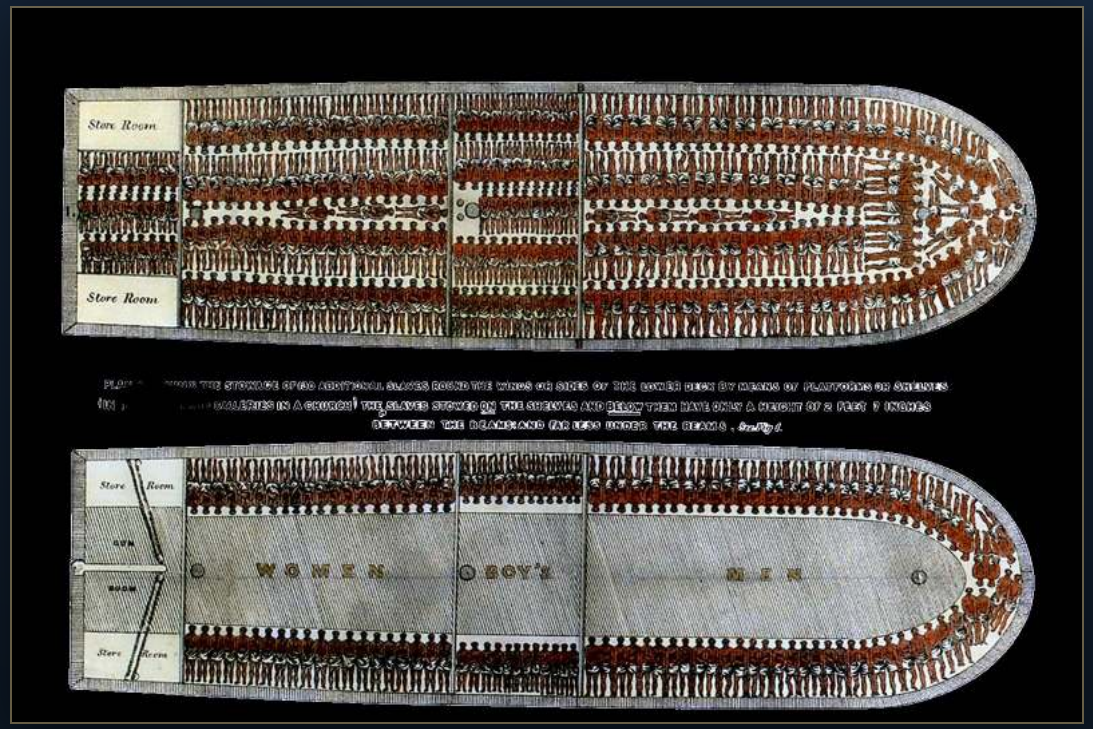
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JOURNEY

The Middle Passage

A brutal voyage with a horrific death toll.

The Middle Passage



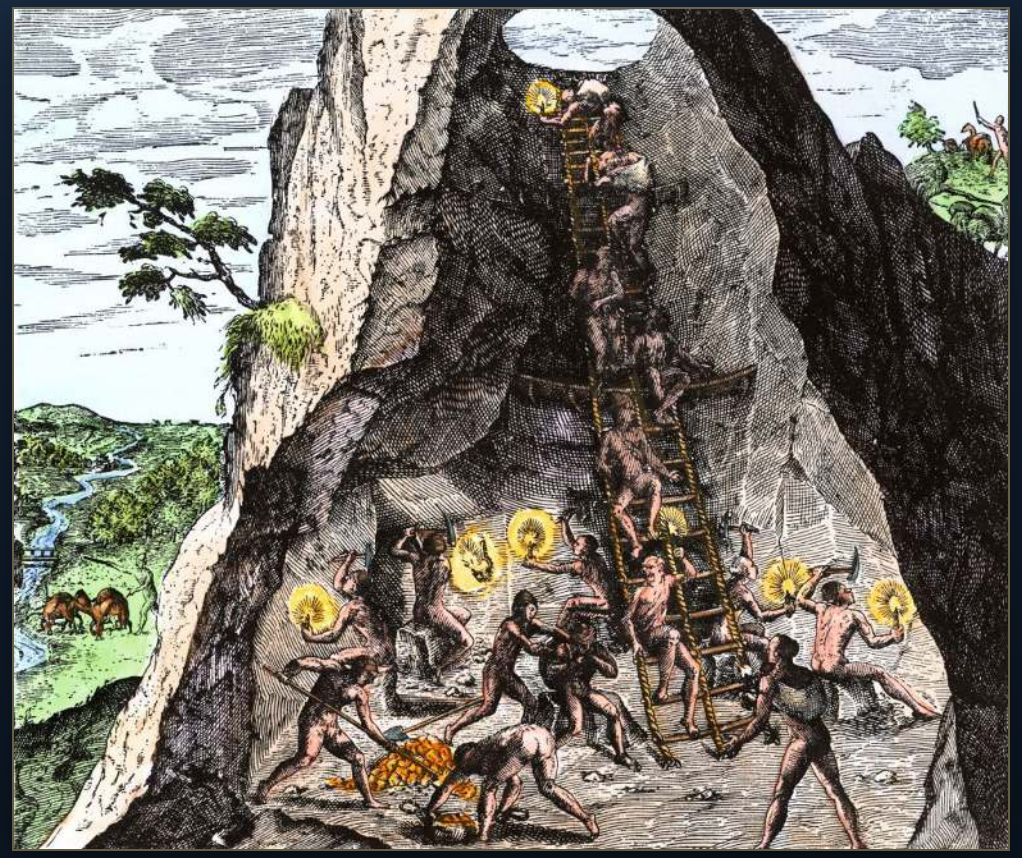
- Enslaved Africans were packed into ships for the **Middle Passage**.
- Roughly 12 million were transported; many died at sea.
- It became the foundation of slavery across the Americas.

SECTION

The Spanish Colonial System

Silver & Forced Labor

- The **encomienda** system forced Native peoples to labor for Spanish colonists.
- Silver mines like **Potosí** ran on brutal forced labor.
- The **repartimiento** later replaced **encomienda** but abuses continued.



The Casta System

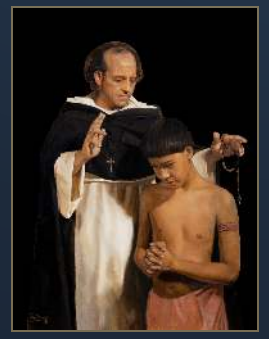
Spanish colonial society was a rigid racial hierarchy

RANK	GROUP	STATUS
1	Peninsulares	Spaniards born in Spain—held the highest offices
2	Creoles	Spaniards born in the Americas
3	Mestizos	Mixed European & Native ancestry
4	Mulattoes	Mixed European & African ancestry
5	Native Americans	Indigenous peoples
6	Africans	Enslaved and free Africans—lowest status

THE TREATMENT DEBATE

Worlds Collide

Two Views of the Conquest



Bartolomé de las Casas

Defender of the Indians

- Documented the atrocities of the conquest.
- Argued Native peoples were rational and should not be enslaved.
- Laid the foundation for later advocates of Indigenous rights.

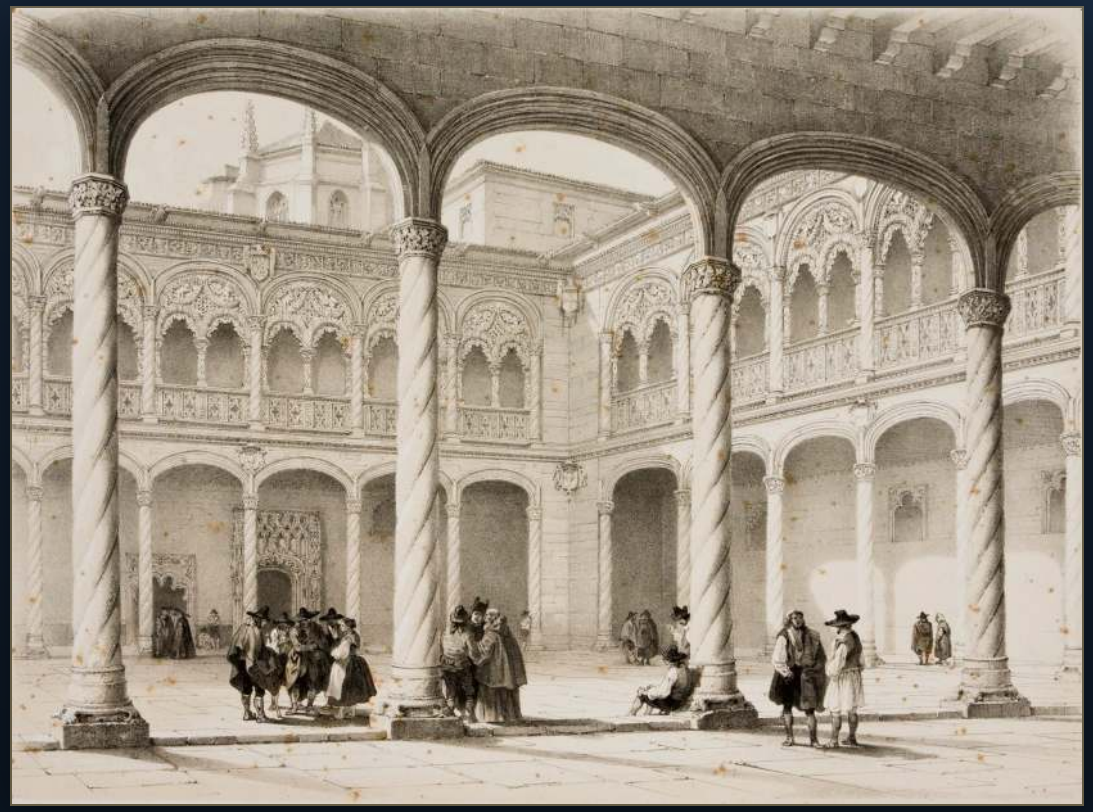


Juan Ginés de Sepúlveda

Defender of Empire

- Argued Native peoples were 'naturally inferior.'
- Claimed they required Spanish masters to become 'civilized.'
- Justified the **encomienda** and forced conversion.

The Valladolid Debate, 1550



- The Spanish crown convened a formal debate over the treatment of Native peoples.
- **Las Casas** and **Sepúlveda** argued their cases before a royal court.
- Though inconclusive, it was one of history's first great debates on human rights.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

Contact & Colonization

1. European motives (**God, Gold & Glory**) and new navigation technology launched an age of exploration and conquest.

2. The **Columbian Exchange** remade both hemispheres—and Old World disease caused a demographic collapse that drove the **Atlantic slave trade**.

3. Spain built a hierarchical colonial order (**encomienda**, **the casta system**), provoking early debates—**Las Casas** vs. **Sepúlveda**—over conquest and human rights.

DISCUSS & APPLY

Contact & Colonization

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Identify the most significant consequence of the **Columbian Exchange** — biological, economic, or cultural — and trace its chain of cause and effect.

COMPARISON

Compare Spanish **justifications** for empire (Sepúlveda) with **critiques** of it (Las Casas). Whose view better fits the evidence?

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How did the **encomienda** and **casta** systems both continue older hierarchies and create something new in the Americas?

Up next — **Lesson 3: Colonial America** (the English colonies take root, 1607–1754)